

Future trends for this year

Watch our interview with the directors of Deloitte Consulting as they give us their tech predictions for the coming year – from tablets to 3G. Find it on the Playware DVD



3D projector add-on

This little projector add-on turns a compatible projector into a 3D capable projection device

drift right? The best part is that it is synced with the direction of the strike. So if for example you were the victim of a sneaky bullet on the back of your right shoulder you'd feel the effect there. If there is a frontal explosion, nearly all of the front actuators would activate to simulate fragmented impact and so on. For those who'd like to feel head shots, or feel bullets whizzing by your helmet, there is the HTX helmet that's coming soon from TN Games. The helmet will communicate with compatible games to give precise, 3 dimensionally accurate impacts where it happens, as it happens.

More for your senses

There are strides being taken to immerse you even further into the media you are experiencing. amBX – short for “ambient experiences” – is a technology developed by Philips Research, that delivers full “sensory surround” entertainment experiences. amBX enables content creators to add real world effects using lighting, colour, rumble and air flow, through licensed amBX devices, to the virtual worlds of computers, games, music, movies and TV entertainment. With amBX the entertainment world can be brought into the real world to create incredible immersive experiences. So imagine an explosion in a game or movie. It will trigger a series of devices that will turn your room bright amber, vibrate the very earth you're sitting on and at the same time blow a gust of hot wind on your face!



3RD space vest

There are some Philips amBX gaming kits available too. These kits comprise of 2.1 speakers that have large hi-intensity RGB LEDs attached to them that flood the ambience with 16 million colors that sync with your games. Besides

this, a host of other peripherals such as a wrist rumble pad that lets you feel every explosion, shot or kick as you play. That's not the end. These kits also come with two 5000 RPM desk top fans that simulate everything from the wind of an approaching

helicopter's blades and strong gush as you navigate a hair pin curve in a racing simulator.

Realised virtuality – the ultimate dream

All of these technologies we've talked about, however impressive, serve to augment your reality and take you further into the action. They leave you with the thought of what's next – would you some day be able to smell the explosions that you witness? If that doesn't sound too pleasing to the senses, how about aromas of Nigella Lawson's delicious culinary delights wafting in your living room as you watch her TV show. In fact, way back in the 1940s smell-o-vision, a combination of TV and smell



amBX enabled ambient lighting and immersive entertainment room

was actively discussed. Warner Brothers even came out with some movies in which scents were released into cinema halls while screening movies. An invention by Professor Takamichi Nakamoto of the Tokyo Institute of Technology is something that can come handy for TVs. The Odour Recorder analyses the qualitative and quantitative composition of the target smell and breaks it down into recipe. Later on by dipping into various chemical cartridges it can reproduce the smell, since its fractional composition is known. For sometime olfactory TVs were being

worked on, but somehow the idea seems to have lost steam.

All of these inventions so far try to enhance your experience, but could there be something that will change the very definition of what reality is? Perhaps create a new sense of



Hospitality and Home Cinema Design with LitStyle Underglow lighting systems controlled by amBX

reality for you? We're talking of serious *Matrix* and *Total Recall* type of simulated reality stuff here. Works of Science Fiction mentions Virtual Reality often; the most famous one was perhaps the Holodeck featured in the *Star Trek* TV series. In this room a virtual environment complete with people, objects, sights sounds would be created. The participants to this holodeck could then interact with these items in the room in a completely real manner. This seems far fetched but several scientists and inventors across the world are trying to achieve it.

A company called Micoy has a Breakthrough Lens Optics Technology that enables creation of 360 degree 3D spherical images for fully immersive environments, putting viewers Inside content displayed in panoramic or dome like environments. They've built an igloo type contraption for this. They even have sphere covered entirely with cameras to capture all angles and an algorithm that decodes and stitches together the images.

These are still attempts at virtual reality, but there is a far more futuristic alternative – stimulated reality. This one involves making the brain feel things that aren't really there. Yes we know – *The Matrix*! A system by which probes will uplink directly with the nervous system and feed it any information needed fooling it into perceiving a reality that isn't actually there. Is there something like that being worked upon? Even if it is, it's probably Level G9 Area 51 classified information. And hence put to work for training and experimental purposes rather than entertainment. Where's Agent 001 when you need him? **d**



HTX Helmet